

The Weight of Too Much Liberty

Police Response to Partisanship in Modern England

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OUTLINE

Introduction

Literature Review

Theory

Hypotheses

Data and Design

Thank you!

Introduction

INTRODUCTION

“The right to protest is a fundamental principle of our democracy, but this is not absolute. A balance must be struck between the rights of individuals and the rights of the hard-working majority to go about their day-to-day business. We cannot have protests conducted by a small minority disrupting the lives of the ordinary public. It’s not acceptable and we’re going to bring it to an end. . . The police asked us for more clarity to crack down on these guerilla tactics, and we have listened.” - Rishi Sunak, 2023

ANECDOTAL EVIDENCE



Figure 1: Police remove signs from protestors leading up to the Coronation

ANECDOTAL EVIDENCE(CONT'D)



Figure 2: Police remove female protestors as they protest police

ANECDOTAL EVIDENCE(CONT'D)



Figure 3: Just Stop Oil protestor removed and imprisoned for 51 weeks

RESEARCH QUESTION

"How does partisanship impact police response in modern England?"

Literature Review

LITERATURE REVIEW

Two Main Accounts of Police Bias:

1. Micro-level: Individual Perceptions
2. Meso-/ Macro-level: Institutional Perceptions

Theory

THEORY

Using partisan theory as a springboard, we postulate that while law enforcement has the ability to dictate the character of government through its actions, this is largely done as a way to maximise their political support.

THEORY(CONT'D)

1. Institutional Socialisation: Though self-selection plays a role in who joins the force, all officers undergo uniform processes of socialisation - meaning they share norms, values, and expectations (Turner, 1997).
2. Rational Choice Institutionalism: Aware of the ontological risk that reform measures pose, police attempt to fortify their own position.
3. Historical Institutionalism: Assuming that law enforcement isn't capable of this broad-scale, long-term political calculus, it adopts 'standard operating procedures'.

Hypotheses

HYPOTHESES

H1: Police will be comparatively more present at Left-wing protests/
comparatively less present at Right-wing protests.

H1.2: Police will be comparatively more severe to Left-wing
protestors/ comparatively less severe to Right-wing protestors.

HYPOTHESES (CONT'D)

H2: Left-leaning constituencies will have comparatively higher rates of discretionary law enforcement/ Right-leaning constituencies will have comparatively lower rates of discretionary law enforcement.

Data and Design

DATA

- 1. ACLED Data:** All available protest data for England which spans from 01.01.20 to 12.31.22
- 2. Street-level Crime Data:** Street-level crime data for anti-social behaviour and public disorder charges in England for 01.01.20 to 12.31.22

ACLED DATA DESIGN

Logisitic Regression using;

Partisanship (IV): left-right hand-coded using political comms and manifestos

Police Response (DV): binary variable assigned via linear SVM

Severity of Response (DV'): categorical variable coded via NB multiclass model

STREET-LEVEL CRIME DATA DESIGN

Territorial Poisson Regression using;

Partisanship (IV): left-right variable assigned by matching geocoded crime data with constituency results from 2019 general election

Police Response (DV): incidence rate of discretionary policing by territory

Thank you!
